

SUMIT KUMAR

has promised what it calls "local manifestos"—hyper-specific documents tailored to the needs of each district. Mathura-Vrindavan, Hathras and Agra will be the first to get theirs, as party chief Akhilesh Yadav promised local partymen at a meeting in Lucknow. Soon, the idea was extended to Noida, Ghaziabad and Baghpat.

WHY THE WEST?

While this promises to reshape how the SP talks to voters ahead of the 2027 assembly election, it cites a twin rationale for starting with these districts, encompassing macro and micro themes. At one level, it speaks of a pincer-grip: continuing social discrimination and overall decline in local economic activity. Flaying the BJP for "deliberate neglect", it linked that to a stifling scenario of endemic corruption, unchecked land mafias, joblessness, poor social infrastructure, and farm and artisanal distress. At another, it vows to zoom in on the nitty-gritty—roads, flyovers, electricity, water supply, drainage, traffic congestion, and the like.

Yet, all this is not without strategic intent. Many believe the decision is rooted in necessity. For the SP, western UP is a crucial battleground. It has sizeable Jat, Muslim and Dalit populations, but also sharp divides that the BJP has often capitalised on.

Analysts say the idea is to find the right rhetoric to match the BJP's ground machinery. The ruling party has long relied on its booth-level network to dominate local conversations, while tying them back to broader ideological appeals. By issuing "local manifestos", the SP is trying to equip its workers with something similar, i.e. a set of talking points and promises that feel relevant in the mohalla or the village square.

Takeaways

- **SP unveils plan for district-level manifestos for 2027 election**
- **Exercise to begin with Agra, Mathura, Hathras, Baghpat, Noida, Ghaziabad**
- **The idea is to marry policy with political aim of challenging BJP**

UP's voters often judge parties not by abstract pledges from Lucknow but by lived realities at the local level: material concerns such as power supply and waterlogging as much as caste discrimination and land disputes. The SP calculates that if it can position itself as attentive to such concerns, it can cut into the BJP's claim of being the only party that gets things done on the ground.

Akhilesh, though, frames it as a genuine developmental initiative going beyond electoral rhetoric—a model that could be replicated across UP. The aim, he argues, is to revive faith in the socialist party's ability to deliver "a harmonious, development-oriented government" if returned to power.

SP MLC Udayveer Singh says the idea is not entirely new, but the focus and commitment to follow through are sharper. "In the past, too, we noted down demands from specific areas and tried to accommodate those in the manifesto. But this time, we will release both a state-level vision document and separate local-level manifestos. This binds not just the local candidate to the promises, but the party as a whole," he tells INDIA TODAY.

AKHILESH'S RESUME

Part of this pitch for 2027 harks back to the past: the SP's track record in governance during Akhilesh's 2012-17 tenure as CM. Recalling projects from his time in Agra, Mathura and Hathras, Akhilesh says the BJP had undone much of that work in the area.

At the same time, the "local manifestos" are also tied to the SP's present and future focus on fortifying its larger PDA plank of social justice—an effort to build a consolidated base of backwards, Dalits and minorities. Under this rubric, a caste census is key to ensuring even and balanced growth, by guaranteeing rights and representation "in proportion to numbers".

All these districts fall within that western arc of the state where chaotic urban sprawls cohabit with straitened kasba and countryside. Human cohorts, too, occupy either side of a yawning gap. That presents an opportunity to bridge electoral tactics and genuine policy. ■